

ANACHRONY

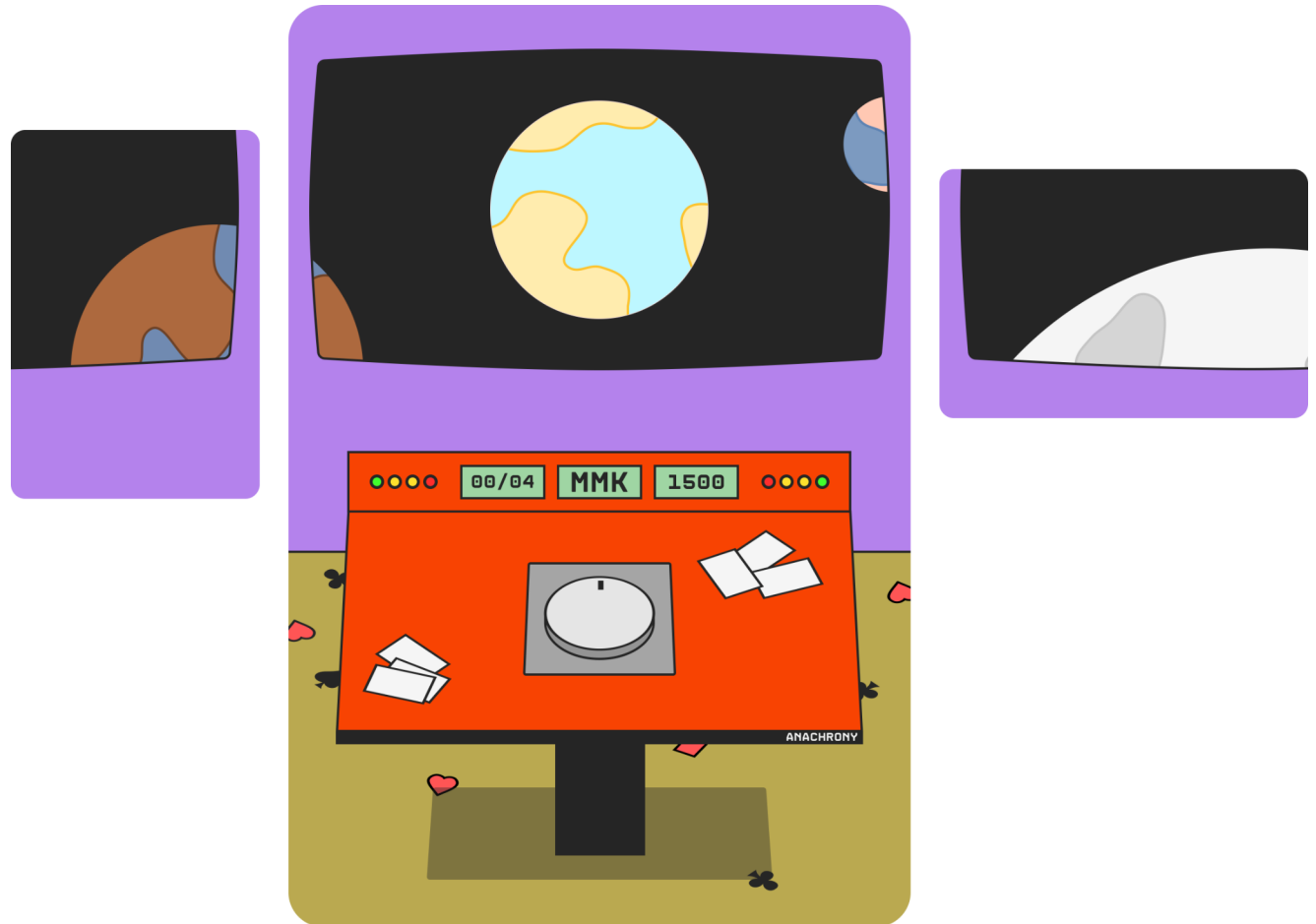
Being a Wild Card

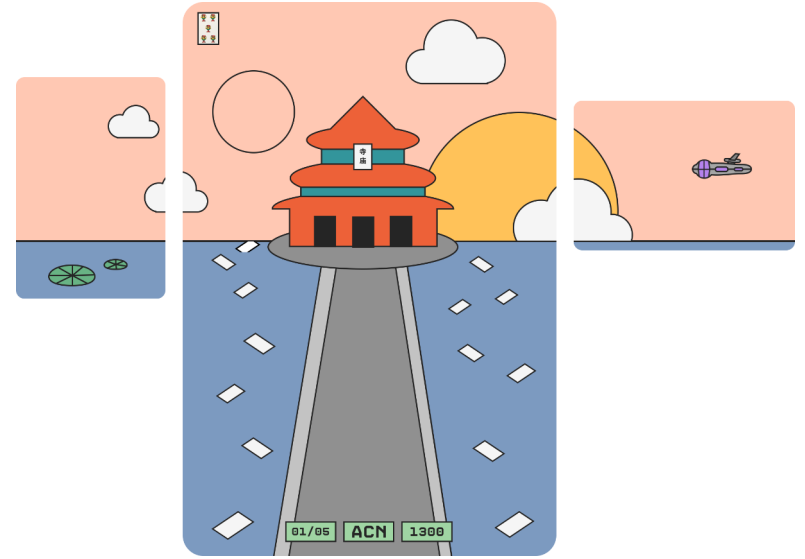
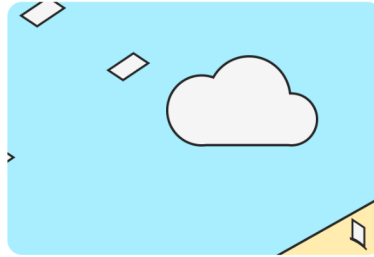
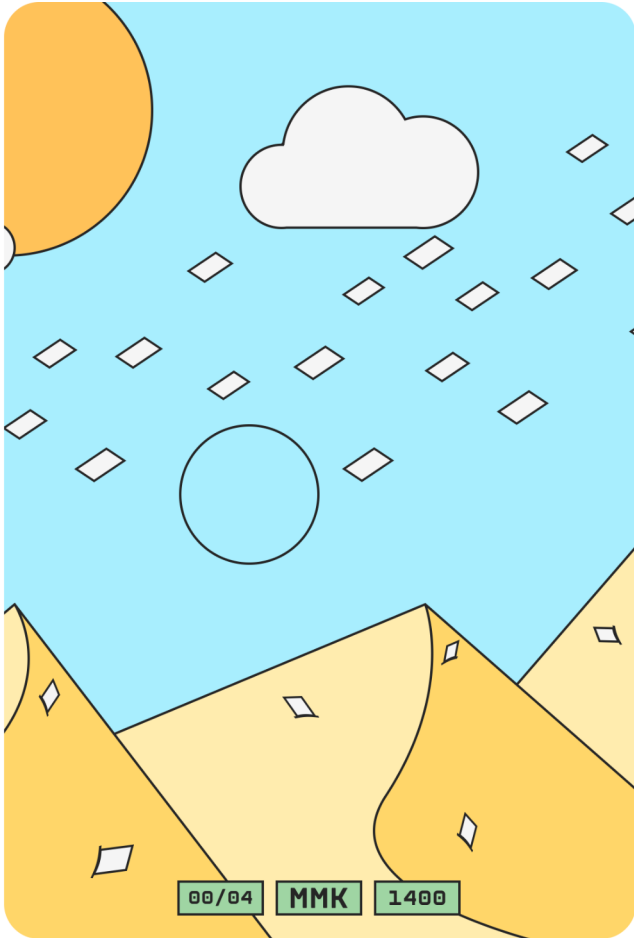
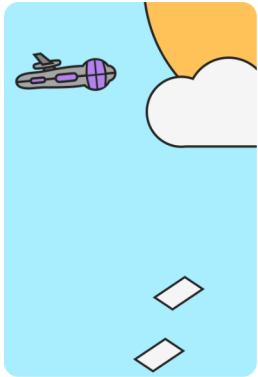
Anachrony

Anachrony is a contemplative interactive installation set inside a spacecraft, where the player sits at the helm and observes time unfold across distant worlds. Through hand-tracking interactions, the player navigates four key eras in the history of playing cards — each represented as a minimalist digital landscape.

In these worlds, cards have slipped out of their time, drifting like fragments of memory. By moving their hands, the player scans the environment to locate and restore these wandering cards to their rightful era. Each discovery reveals a short story or fun fact about the card's cultural origin, turning exploration into a learning experience as well as a visual journey.

As more cards are recovered, the fractured timelines begin to realign, yet something feels off. In the final sequence, the player learns that the temporal disorder was caused by the Joker — a **wild card** tired of being undefined, trying to steal the identity of others... before ultimately taking the player's own.





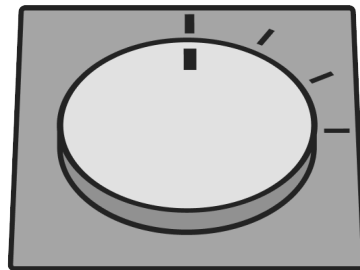
The Interface - Key visuals



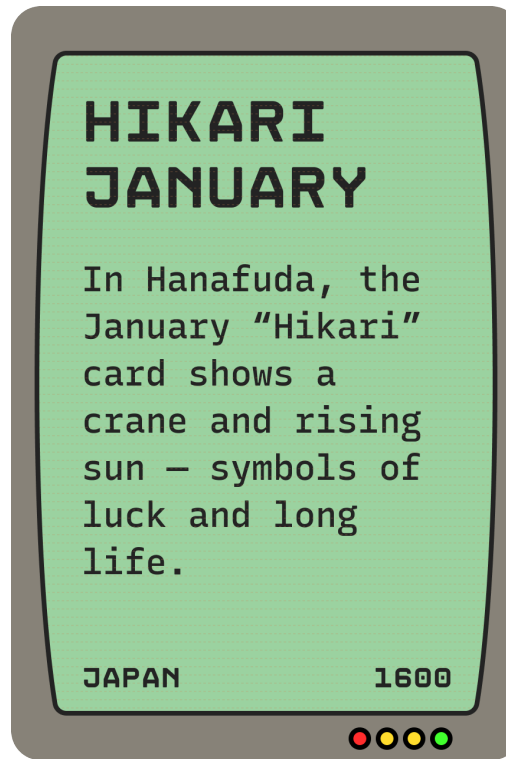
Dashboard - world information



Magnifier - card revelator



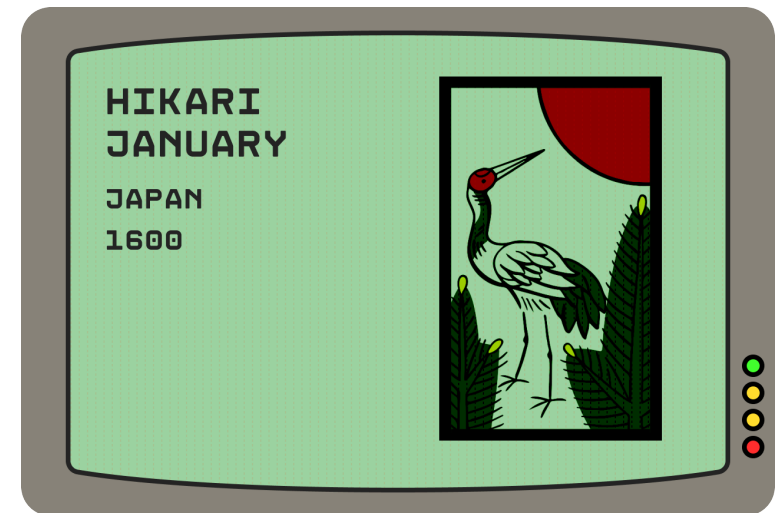
Button- world switcher



Left screen - card fact



MMK - Mamluk World



Right screen - card design

User Journey

0-SBY : The installation rests in standby mode. When the player approaches and sits in front of the screen, the system recognizes their presence and awakens. The spacecraft lights up, inviting them to begin.

1-VSL : Seated at the ship's controls, the player turns a virtual dial with their hand to travel between worlds. After each journey, they return to the cockpit, where the recovered cards appear on the control table. Subtle clues hint that the ship belongs to the Joker

World sequences : Across the following worlds, the player repeats the same contemplative interaction — using hand gestures to find and collect misplaced cards. Some are blank, others in their proper era, a few out of place. Each discovery reveals a glimpse of its origin before the player returns to the ship.

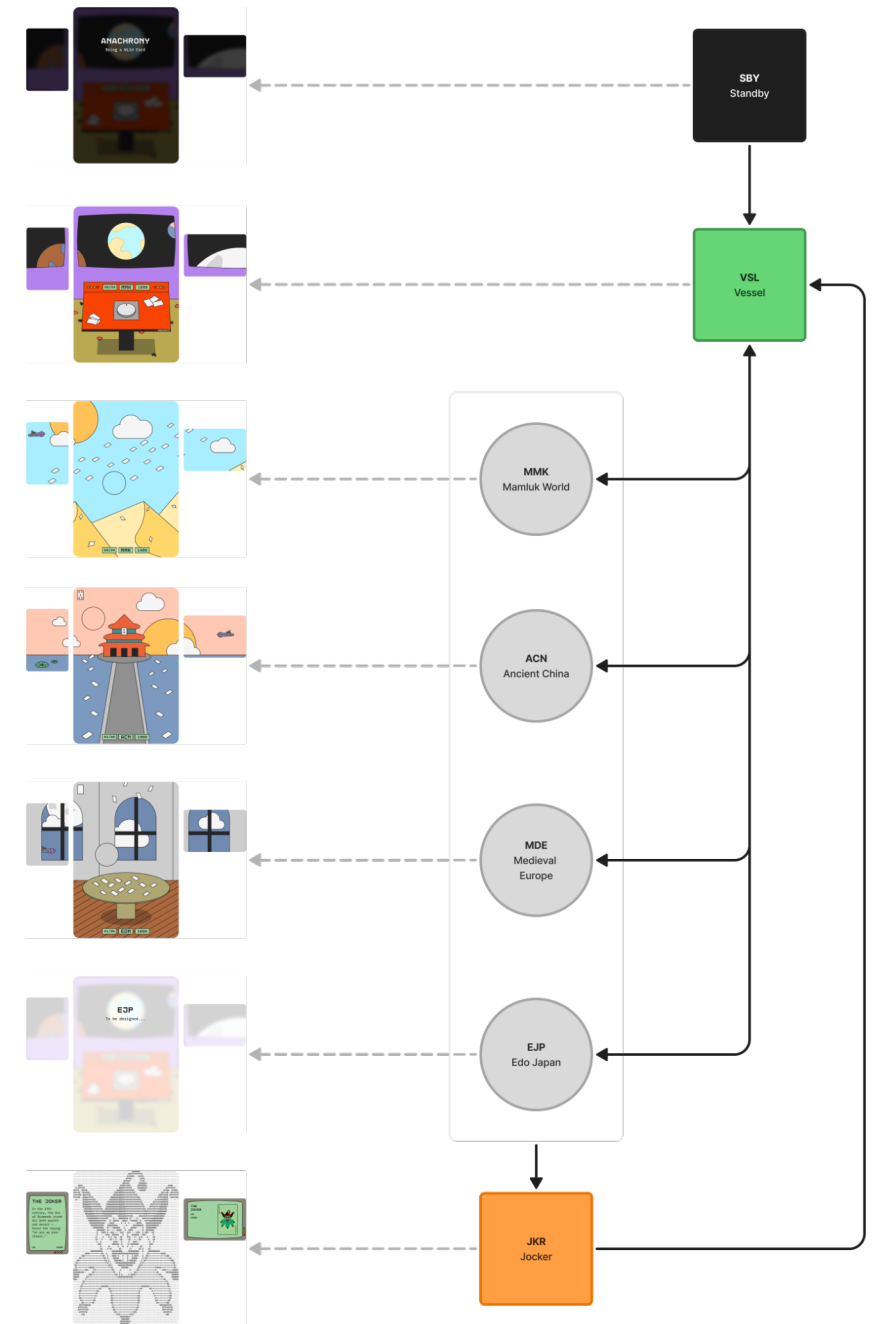
2-MMK : The player is in a Mamluk desert. Cards drift slowly through the sky like fragments of time.

3-ACN : The player stands before an ancient Chinese temple. Cards float on calm water, reflecting the passing time.

4-EMD : The player is inside a medieval European castle. Cards fall gently from the ceiling onto a large wooden table.

5-EJP : To be designed.

6-JKR : Back in the ship, the player encounters the Joker, materialized as shifting ASCII characters — a digital reflection of the machine and of themselves. With a hand gesture, they dissolve the characters, breaking free. The cockpit lights fade to black. When a new visitor sits down, the system awakens once again — the loop begins anew.



Field observations

Journey

My research began with the materiality of playing cards — their texture, manufacturing processes, and physical properties. This led me to study the objects and gestures of cheating, as a way to understand how material and manipulation intertwine.

From there, I explored the mirror ("shiner") as an interface — a poetic object that reveals what is usually invisible. The mirror later gave way to the story of Bianco's 19th-century scam, where cards became tools of deception and illusion.

When this narrative became too narrow, it coincided with the moment we formed groups and began merging ideas. The project quickly evolved into a collection of disparate mini-games, closer to WarioWare than to a cohesive narrative experience. This lack of depth led me to step back and rebuild the conceptual framework.

After our group split up, I decided to continue the project on my own. I based my installation on the card-collecting mechanic and the story of the Joker. I designed a flexible system able to cover different eras and cultures related to playing cards, connected through a main narrative inspired by the Joker's dual nature. The installation also shares short anecdotes while displaying various card designs.

Insights

Story of the Jocker

The Joker is a wild card — one that can represent any other. He "teaches people not to take life too seriously" and "sees the whole world as a game."

Linked to Le Mat (The Fool) in tarot, he embodies both the beginning and the end of a journey.

Collection as central mechanic

Inspired by Pokémon and the Pokédex, the project uses collection as a way to tell stories through discovery and repair — a kind of bestiary of playing cards. This mechanic recalls early collectible cards hidden in everyday products like cigarette packs.

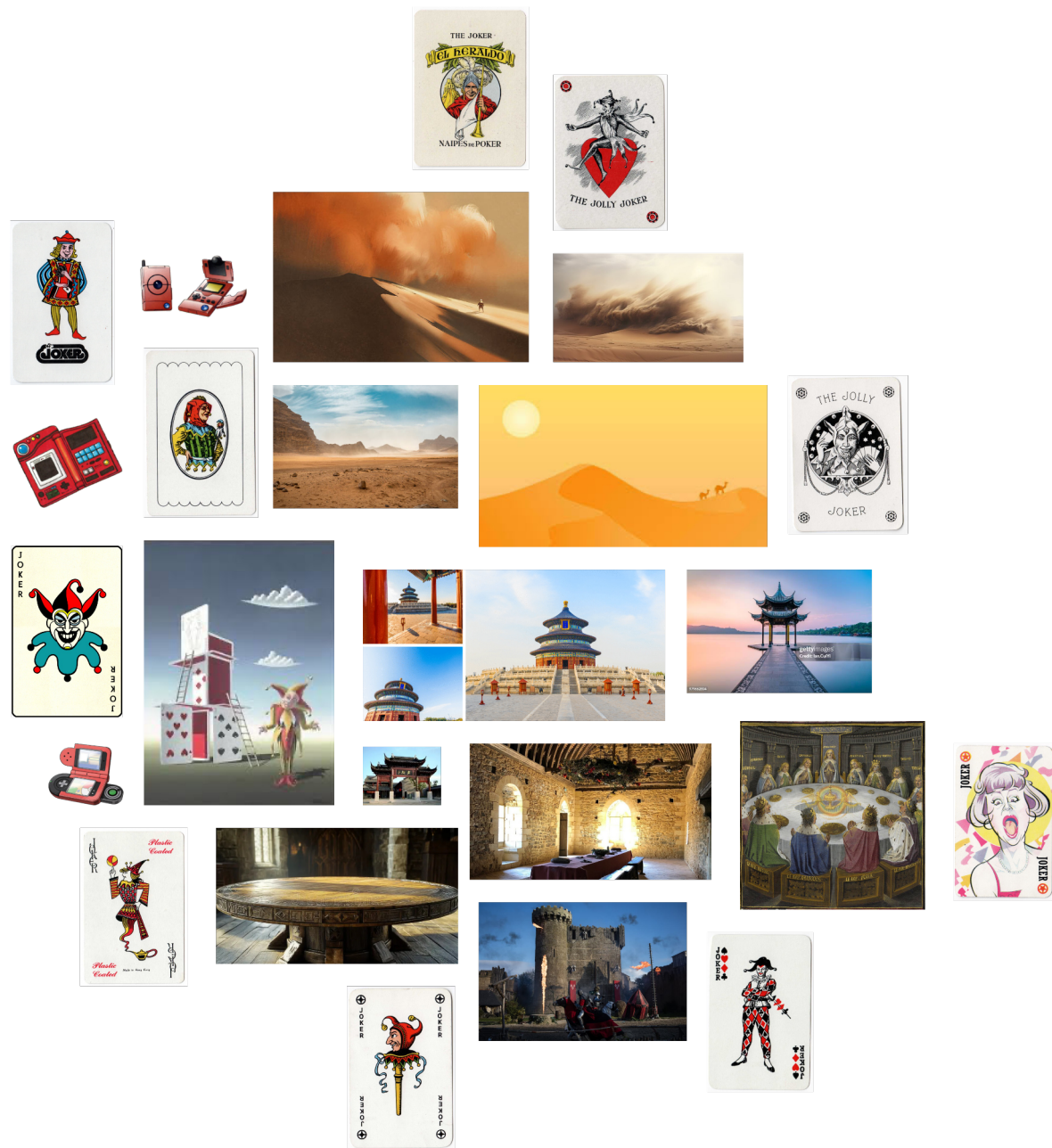
Creative coding workshop

The creative coding workshop served to test gestures as storytelling tools and explore possibilities with Media Pipe library. The interaction was refined to a single hand movement — holding to confirm — emphasizing time and intention. The main goal was to make onboarding optional, where the gesture itself provides sufficient affordance.

Visuals inspirations

The wooden screen installation combines the aesthetics of playing card shapes, the Pokédex, and the fragility of a card castle. The visual style blends cartoon and early video-game influences — somewhere between a children's illustration and a soft-edged 8-bit interface. This simple, playful design leaves space for the imagination while keeping the focus on the cards themselves, which serve as the main visual and narrative elements of the experience.

Each world reinterprets landscapes from different eras and cultures through minimalist 2D environments.



User Tests

Since the project was restarted from scratch on 2025 October 17 , the user tests conducted before that date are no longer relevant.

2025-11-06

Tests were conducted in class with participants who had never seen the project before.

To test

- Multi-screen information display
- Gesture discoverability
- Systematics: hunting for fun facts

Feedback

- Difficult to interact and read at the same time
- Unclear which cards need to be found
- The link to the Joker isn't understood until the end
- Hard to reach the screen's edges with hand gestures

2025-11-11

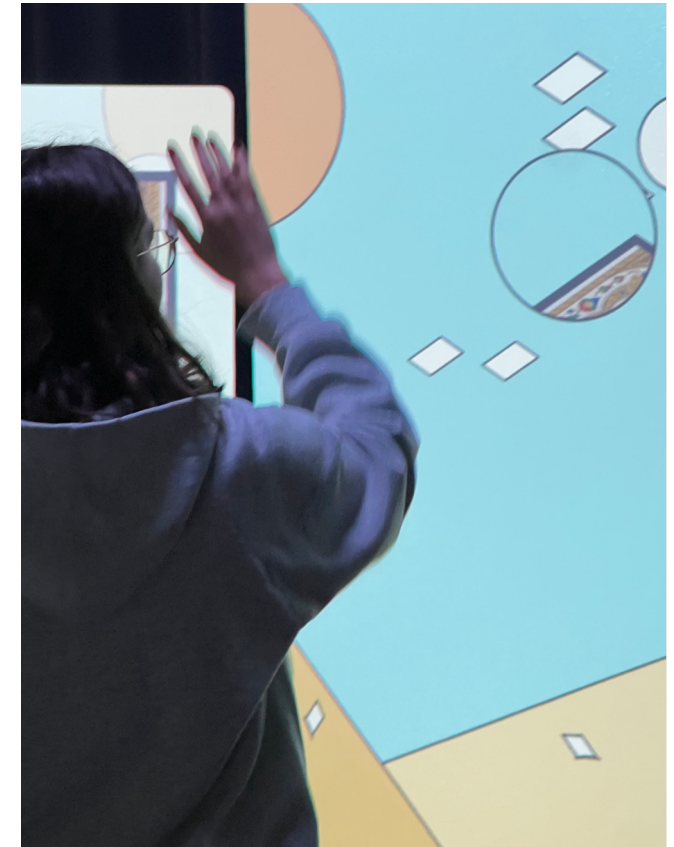
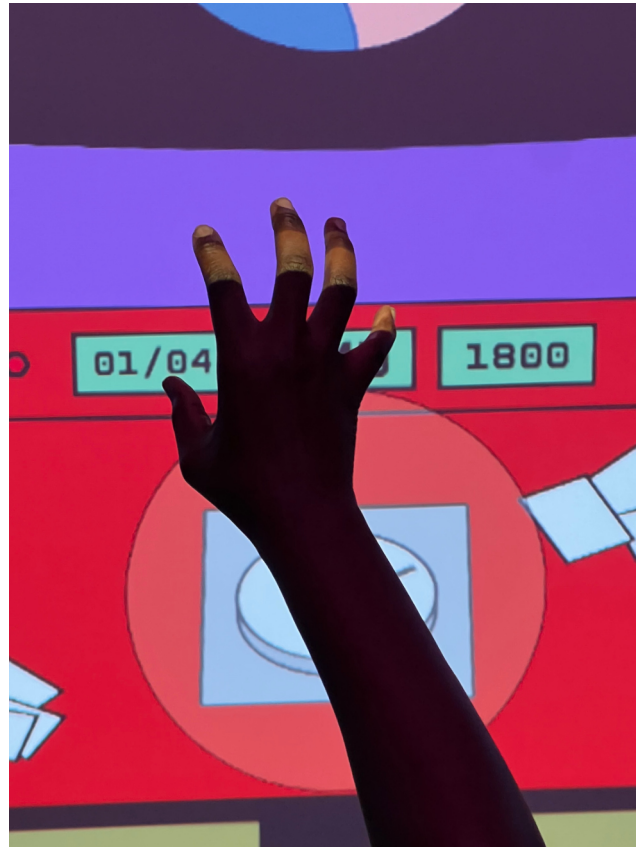
Class test with Pierre, Laure, and Roky.

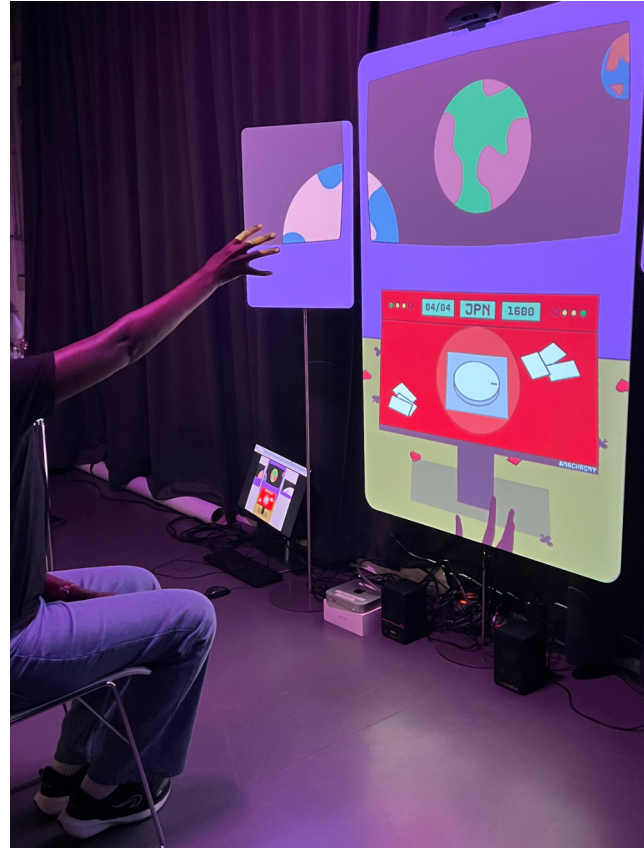
To test

- Gestures used to turn the knob
- Understanding the mechanics of navigating between scenes
- General user experience

Feedback

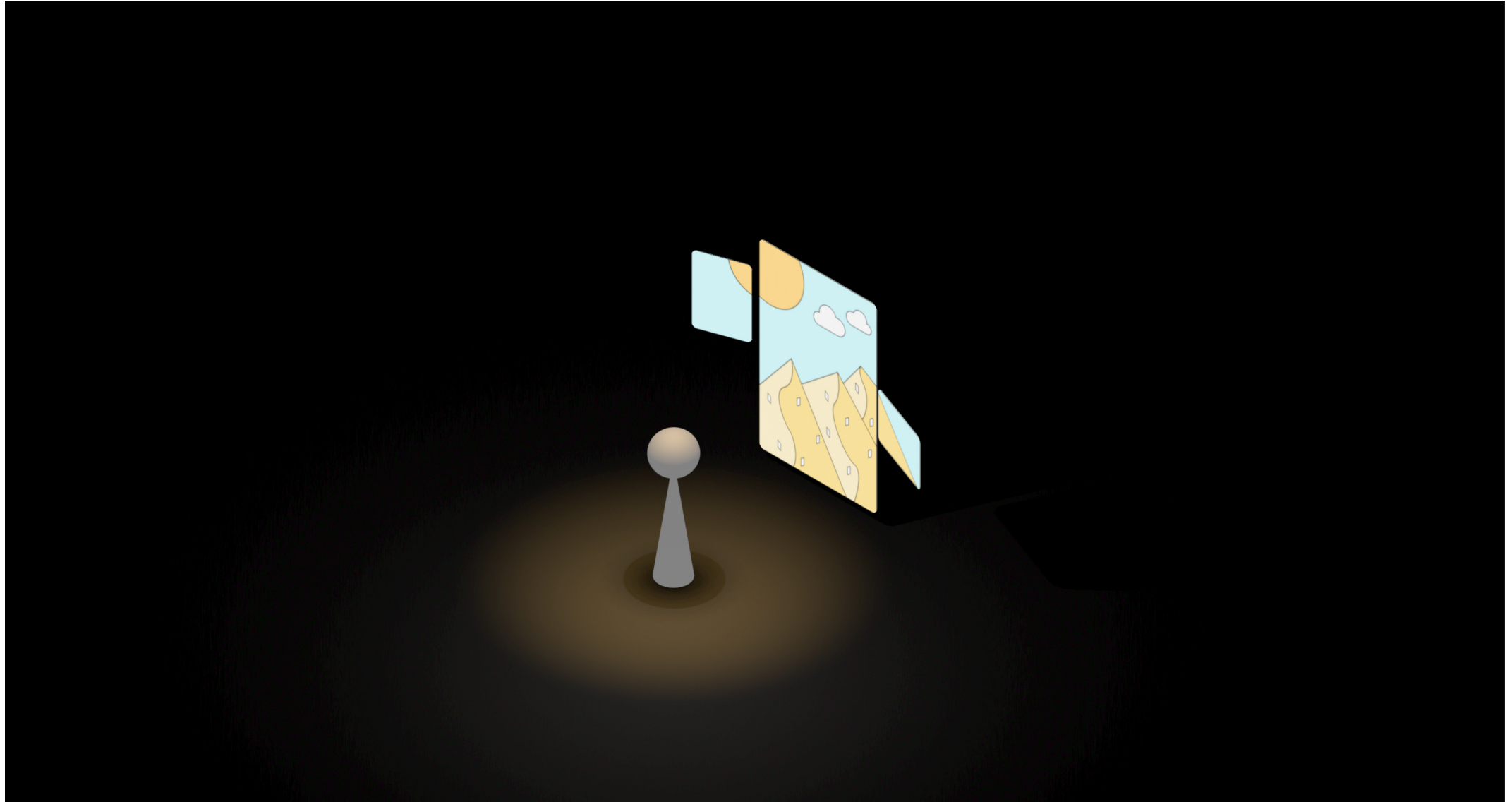
- The player doesn't realize that the knob has steps (detents)
- Users tend to grab the knob from the top or bottom rather than from the sides
- Card information still doesn't stay visible long enough



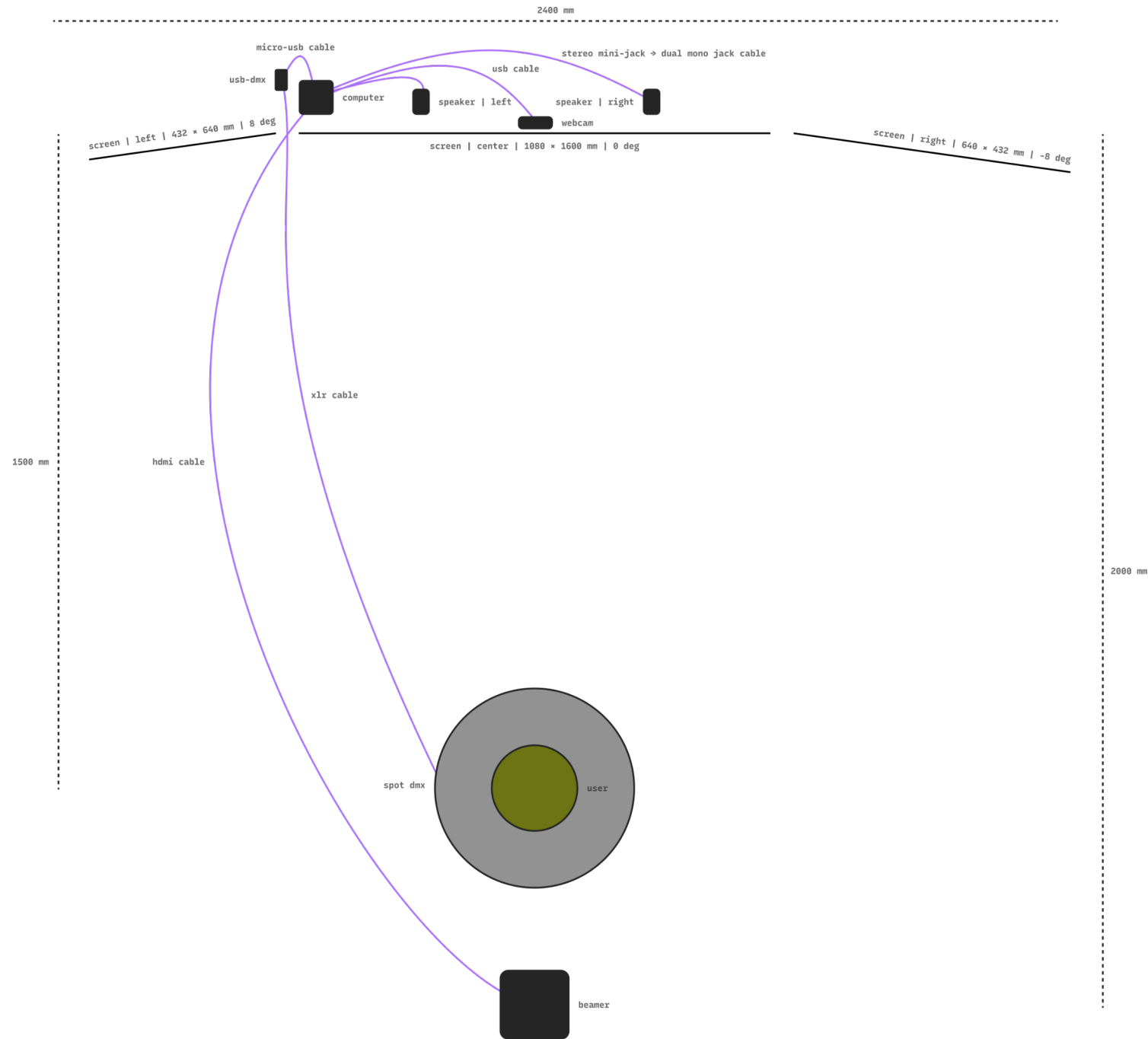


Scenography

A representation of the player in front of the screen,
illuminated by a DMX spotlight in the color of the scene.



Spatial diagram



Technical diagram

Footprint

- Floor area: 2300 × 1500 mm

Structure

- 3 white melamine wood panels (4 mm thick):
 - Left: 432 × 640 mm
 - Center: 1080 × 1600 mm
 - Right: 640 × 432 mm
- 3 metal stands with base plates, min. height 1700 mm
- 1 comfortable chair

Projection & Display

- 1 short- or mid-throw projector (e.g. BenQ)
 - 1 HDMI cable
- 1 Mac mini M2 (minimum)
 - 1 USB-C multiport hub (HDMI, USB-A, Ethernet)
- 1 control monitor (e.g. Dell)
 - 1 HDMI cable
- 1 keyboard + mouse

Audio

- 2 speakers
- 1 stereo mini-jack to dual mono jack cable

Lighting & Tracking

- 1 × DMX spot
- 1 × USB-DMX converter
- 1 × XLR cable
- 1 × webcam (e.g. Konftel)

Power & Connectivity

- Power cables, extension cords, and multi-socket strips

Software

- Google Chrome
- MadMapper